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Graduate Recruitment Team

Lazard

50 Stratton Street

London W1J 8LL

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the 2027 London Financial Advisory Full-Time Analyst Programme in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Lazard's role advising SunOpta on its \$1.1 billion sale to Refresco in 2026 sits squarely in the food and agribusiness territory I have spent the past year analysing.

My clearest preparation for banking has been taking transactions apart. As co-founder and Treasurer of the Strathclyde AgriCapital Society, the university's first agri-finance society, I grew membership to 126 and led weekly research sessions on deals such as Olam Agri's USD 1.24bn stake sale to SALIC, explaining the strategic rationale, the deal structure and the valuation to members, including many from outside finance. My strongest academic results are in the same territory: 90% in first-year Finance and 78%, the second-highest mark, in a third-year group project for Advanced Corporate Finance and Financial Markets.

Investment banking appeals to me because every transaction is a chain of judgements about who should buy, why now and at what price, and each one has to survive scrutiny from clients and counterparties. The analyst's part in that chain is accuracy under deadline, a habit I have built outside the classroom. For nearly two years at KONG, I reconciled end-of-shift cash and card takings while studying full-time. I now run the drinks programme as Head Mixologist at Le Set, a new 200-cover Glasgow venue, where I wrote the batch specifications and trained around 15 bar staff to standards that have to hold when someone else executes them.

Lazard's independent advisory model stands out to me because the firm's reputation rests on the quality of its advice, and its 2026 mandates range from NextEra Energy's combination with Dominion Energy, at a combined enterprise value of around \$420 billion the largest energy deal on record, to SunOpta's \$1.1 billion sale to Refresco. Having spent a year explaining agribusiness deals such as Olam Agri's stake sale to SALIC, and with a dissertation on how governments hedge oil-price risk, I would welcome the chance to learn how Lazard's bankers frame rationale and valuation for boards in exactly these sectors.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan